

Impressions, Ideas, and Habit: Hume's Empiricist Theory of Mind

An original lesson plan inspired by **David Hume's** *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or David Hume. Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/9662>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	65 minutes	Epistemology

“According to Hume, everything in our minds — even our wildest ideas — is built out of raw sensory impressions. Is that really true, and what happens to knowledge if it is?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Hume's distinction between impressions and ideas and his Copy Principle, that all ideas are ultimately derived from prior impressions.
- Apply Hume's account of causation as constant conjunction plus habitual expectation to a concrete cause-and-effect example to test what it does and doesn't claim.
- Evaluate whether the "missing shade of blue" case undermines Hume's Copy Principle and defend a position on whether his account of causation threatens the objectivity of scientific laws.

Materials Needed

- Excerpted passages from Sections II, IV, and VII of the *Enquiry* (public-domain Gutenberg edition, printed)
- Whiteboard for the impressions/ideas diagram
- Two billiard balls or similar objects as a physical prop for the causation discussion
- Index cards for the closing activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Imagine a New Color

8 min

Ask students to try to imagine a color they have genuinely never seen before — not a mixture of known colors, an entirely new one. Most will struggle or fail, which sets up Hume's empiricist claim that imagination works by copying and recombining what the senses have already delivered.

Direct Instruction: Impressions and Ideas

15 min

Introduce Hume's foundational distinction between impressions (vivid, immediate perceptions — sensations and feelings) and ideas (fainter copies of impressions used in thinking and memory), and his Copy Principle that all simple ideas derive from corresponding simple impressions. Introduce the "missing shade of blue" puzzle as Hume's own acknowledged counterexample: a person who has seen every shade of blue except one could, Hume grants, imagine that missing shade purely from the pattern, without ever having had the impression.

Guided Reading and Demonstration: Cause and Effect

20 min

Strike one billiard ball into another and ask what students actually observe versus what they infer — do they ever perceive a "force" or "necessary connection" making the second ball move, or only the regular sequence of contact followed by motion? Read the key passage where Hume argues that all we ever really observe is "constant conjunction," and that our idea of necessary causal connection comes from a habit of the mind formed by repetition, not from anything perceived in the objects themselves.

Whole-Class Discussion

15 min

Discuss the implications: if causation is just a psychological habit of expecting one event after another rather than a real necessary link we perceive, does this threaten the objectivity of scientific laws, which are typically stated as necessary rather than merely habitual connections? Contrast this with the idea that Hume may simply be redefining what causation is, rather than denying its reality.

Closure

7 min

Exit ticket: does the missing-shade-of-blue exception undermine the Copy Principle, and does Hume's account of causation change how confident students should be in cause-and-effect claims they encounter in the news or in science class?

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does the "missing shade of blue" genuinely violate Hume's Copy Principle, or is it a minor, containable exception he can grant without damaging the overall theory?
- 2 When one billiard ball strikes another, do we ever actually perceive a "necessary connection" causing the motion, or only a regular sequence of events — and if only the latter, what does that make of our ordinary talk of one thing "making" another happen?
- 3 If our confidence in cause and effect ultimately rests on habit rather than reason or direct perception, does this mean scientific claims about causation are on shakier ground than we usually assume?
- 4 Is Hume denying that causation exists, or offering an analysis of what causation actually is — regularity plus expectation — that differs from our naive picture of "necessary connection"? Does this distinction matter?
- 5 Hume claims all substantive knowledge of the world rests on experience, never on reason alone. Are there any ideas or beliefs you hold that seem to resist being traced back to sensory impressions?

Assessment

Students write a short paper explaining Hume's account of causation as constant conjunction plus habitual expectation, applying it to a cause-and-effect claim of their own choosing, and evaluating whether this account changes what they think science can legitimately claim about causal "laws." Grade on accurate representation of Hume's actual position and a clear original application.

Extension Activity

Assign students to read a short excerpt from Section X of the Enquiry, "Of Miracles" (freely available via the Gutenberg link), and write a reading response connecting Hume's skeptical empiricism about causation to his separate argument that no testimony could ever be strong enough to establish a miracle.

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